CHAPTER SIX

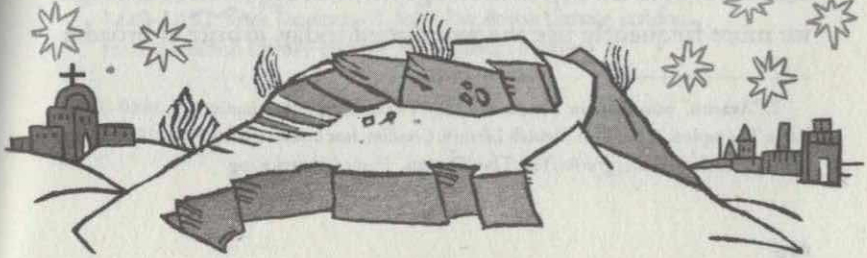
AVARICE AND MERCY: HEDGEHOG AND OLIVE OIL

Sow ye for yourselves rightfulness in truth, and reap ye in the mouth of mercy, and make ye new to you a field newly brought to fallow. For it is time to seek the Lord, and when he cometh, he shall rain blessings upon you.

—Hosea 10:12 (Middle English Bible)

The quality of mercy is not strained.
It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven
Upon the place beneath. It is twice blessed:
It blesseth him that gives and him that takes.

—William Shakespeare



In a medieval prayer book now called *The Dunois Hours*, a personification of Avarice rides across the manuscript page.[1] Avarice is a vacant-eyed young man, almost unfocused around the edges, who holds a chest filled with gold. But Avarice and his gold pale in comparison to the creature he is astride: a massive monkey. The monkey looks frighteningly sharp and aware as it gazes directly at the viewer of the prayer book. Behind man and monkey, heaps of coins gleam unnoticed upon a table. Another man slightly off-frame carries a giant money bag and tries to hand it to absent-minded Avarice.

The illumination resembles a dreamscape, a world where everything is slightly off-kilter. Avarice's feet aren't visible. His robes part a little, only to reveal more fur. Is it the fur of his mantle or the fur of the monkey? Is he melting into the monkey? At any rate, Avarice is unperturbed. Defying our expectations, he ignores the man handing him more gold (shouldn't he be greedily grasping it?), continuing to stare absently at the casket in his lap.

Avarice seems to have a tenuous grasp on reality—which is exactly the point. Theft, miserliness, and hoarding money are all merely symptoms of something more severe and insidious. *Avarice has lost the ability to see true value.* Bad accounting (forgive me the pun).

Avarice is the capacious term for a whole host of disordered attitudes about money, material goods, and acquisition. Though we more frequently use the word *greed* today, *avarice* is broader

1. "Avarice," miniature in *The Dunois Hours*, manuscript illumination, ca. 1440–1450, Yates Thompson 3, fol. 174r, British Library, London, last updated May 23, 2018, https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_Dunois_Hours_Avarice.jpg.

"Avarice," miniature in *The Dunois Hours*, manuscript illumination, ca. 1440–1450, Yates Thompson 3, fol. 174r, British Library, London. From the British Library archive / Bridgeman Images

than *greed*.[2] Money is not evil per se; it can either help us or impede us in our vocation to love. Avaricious actions and attitudes include both hoarding and the burning desire to acquire, but they also include paired opposites like stinginess and extravagance, or particular actions like usury (lending with interest), simony (the selling of spiritual offices or sacraments), theft, and withholding. This cluster of behaviors and character qualities falls under the habit of valuing one's money or material goods higher than other lives around oneself. Avarice entails a growing and even cultivated blindness to the needs of others in pursuit of the glittering mirage of one's own material desires and goals. Because of this nurtured ignorance, avarice is a mother to injustice, corruption, slavery of all varieties, and systemic poverty.

In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus's exposition on the shape of the life following him further up and further in to the kingdom of heaven, he describes the kinds of treasures we are called to gather:

> Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
>
> The eye is the lamp of the body. If your eyes are healthy, your whole body will be full of light. But if your eyes are unhealthy, your whole body will be full of darkness. If then the light within you is darkness, how great is that darkness!
>
> No one can serve two masters. Either you will hate the one and love the other, or you will be devoted to the one and

2. For more on the development of avarice as a concept, see Richard Newhauser's *The Early History of Greed* (Cambridge University Press, 2000).

> despise the other. You cannot serve both God and money (Matt. 6:19–24 NIV).

Jesus's comment on quality of vision, sandwiched between considerations of attitudes toward money and material goods, almost seems like an aside. But it is not. Our relationships to money and material goods guide our ability to recognize true value, to evaluate well, to judge well.

Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. If avarice is the self-inflicted bad reckoning of value, mercy is above all the habit of seeing the hidden treasure, the image of God, in other people, especially when such sight is difficult or nearly impossible. Mercy restores the rightful relationship between goods and people.

Why mercy and not the more expected antidotes to avarice, like generosity or liberality? Generosity and liberality, as giving beyond what is expected, are beautiful, much-needed virtues that should not be underestimated. They often appear in medieval writing as part of the array of antidotes to avaricious habits. But unmoored from mercy, generosity or liberality can participate in systems of patronage and giving that reinforce the hierarchies of the deserving and the undeserving. I give my hard-earned money to you because you have none (or, sometimes implicitly, *because you have failed/are lesser/can't do it*). Aren't I great? Aren't you grateful?

In contrast, mercy is a friend to those the world has learned to ignore: the guilty, the disabled, the sick, the weak, the sinners. In other words, every single person needs mercy. Mercy shatters the rigidity of judging value solely through earning and growth charts and good grades. It reveals in daylight the tawdry, false sheen of boot-straps success and narratives of self-making. Mercy belongs to redemptive reckoning as it allows one to recognize and

value people in their truest identities beyond present circumstances of evil, indigence, or error—children of God, brothers and sisters in Christ, made for love itself. Mercy looks through the eyes of the crucified Jesus, who called out from the cross for divine mercy toward those torturing him while they were dividing his last earthly possessions (Luke 23:34). This true vision heals the plague of spiritual unseeing caused by avarice.

Becoming Beastly

The relationship between wrongful evaluation of goods and spiritual blindness is ironic because in our topsy-turvy world, money usually gives a person visibility and significance. Wealth and power go together like bread and butter. Even *The Dunois Hours* survives because it is a precious luxury item, richly illustrated and carefully kept for hundreds of years. The artifacts of the wealthy survive, while we barely know about the lives of the poor. The needs of wealthy nations are attended to, the desires of those with money seen and answered. Wealth does not bestow on us the inherent value we already possess as children of God, but it makes us and our desires visible in the world's hardscrabble, time-bound wrestle of desire and need. Our acquisition is rewarded because hoarding and collecting proffer a worldly visibility and power hard to reject.

Jacob's Well notes that the avaricious man or woman is like an otter, a fox, and a hedgehog. One could decorate a baby's room with such a cute bunch of forest critters (although that seems like a bad beginning for moral formation). In the medieval imagination, each of these animals illustrates a different form of avarice. *Jacob's Well* explains: The otter stockpiles fish that inevitably begin to

stink and sicken the poor otter. The fox is a "deceivable beast" who "devoureth and slayeth" his neighbor in pursuit of his desires.[3] In the medieval bestiaries, the adorable hedgehog goes about with his "scharpe pryckys" to gather a great store of apples, excessively profiting off the hard work of others for his own enjoyment.[4] There are numerous charming medieval illuminations of the hedgehog with his apples collected on his spines, trundling back to his lair.

Charm aside, these comparisons remind the viewer how particular orientations toward goods can make us act like unreasoning animals. In our desire for objects, we forget people. This temptation is available to everyone, whether you have a lot of money or a little. Bad habits concerning money cause those distinctively human powers—rationality and good judgment—to unravel and communal vision to dim. Every exploitative system, from human trafficking to slavery to chronically underpaid workers manufacturing cheap goods for ravenous Western appetites overseas, grows out of a wrongful evaluation of money over lives. Humans have even wreaked ecological catastrophe in the throes of avaricious consumption. Think of fast-fashion clothing filling up landfills or large-scale mining causing the devastation of landscapes, animal habitats, and water supplies. On an individual level, a person can elevate their desire for the perfect vacation experience or outfit over caring how the service workers or clothing makers are treated in the process. In this instrumentalizing invisibility, avarice destroys community as it elevates the desires of one individual or a

3. *Jacob's Well: An English Treatise on the Cleansing of Man's Conscience*, ed. Arthur Brandeis (Oxford: Horace Hart, Printer, 1900), 117–18.

4. *Jacob's Well*, 118; see also *Book of Beasts: The Bestiary in the Medieval World*, ed. Elizabeth Morrison (J. Paul Getty Museum, 2019), 22, for an explanation of the fox up to his wily tricks in bestiaries with example illuminations; on the hedgehog, see Ann Payne, *Medieval Beasts* (New Amsterdam, 1990), 59.

very small group above the needs of the many and, in the process, teaches a false gospel that one is self-made. Examples abound: in lobbyists enticing politicians to act against the will of their constituents through massive campaign donations, in companies raking in billions while raising prices of food, in churches covering up abuse for fear of a lawsuit, in a billionaire living in a mansion while mere miles away ten people crash in a roach-ridden apartment.

If humans are "dependent rational animals," in the apt phrase of the moral philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre, following the understanding of Saint Thomas Aquinas and Aristotle, avarice causes us to lose our sense of reckoning and valuing other people—to become undiscerning beasts.[5] Our spiritual eyes become clouded as we lose our ability to weigh value beyond what we can grasp in our sweaty paws.

Money Matters

Does this mean that any extraneous possessions at all, outside of the basics, are bad? Should we all make a vow of poverty? Philosopher Fr. Andrew Pinsent notes this difficulty in discerning avarice: "One of the peculiarities of the relationship of money and virtue is that there are cases of heroic virtue under surprisingly diverse conditions of material wealth."[6] Pinsent gives examples ranging from Saint Francis of Assisi, a young aristocrat who cast aside *all* his wealth, to Saint Homobonus, patron saint of businesspeople, who did all kinds of good with his money in

5. From Alasdair MacIntyre, *Dependent Rational Animals* (Notre Dame: Notre Dame University Press, 1999).

6. Andrew Pinsent, "Avarice and Liberality," in *Virtues and Their Vices*, ed. Kevin Timpe and Craig A. Boyd (Oxford University Press, 2014), 163.

his small Italian town. If we hold too tightly to any one particular inflexible, universal rule about money, we tend to get into trouble. Think of the hypocritical religious leaders of Christ's day, tithing even the smallest portion of spices but unseeing of the needs of others (Luke 11:42).[7]

What matters more is *how* we make money and *what* we do with it. In the Middle Ages, controversies raged around the Dominican and Franciscan friars. They had vowed to live in voluntary poverty, subsisting on alms, unlike traditional professed religious like the Benedictines, who lived in monasteries off both donations and the land. Many theologians and writers, including William Langland, the poet of *Piers Plowman*, felt that this voluntary poverty actually made the friars *more* vulnerable to the sway of money, not less.[8] Wealthy laypeople would bribe wandering friars to give them light penance in exchange for their confessions. This is simony, the sin of selling spiritual goods such as spiritual positions of authority and even sacraments. To give someone "short shrift" means to listen to a truncated confession (shrift) and impose the lightest of penance in return, neither giving their vices the proper attention nor fostering the depth of contrition needed for real spiritual change and communal harmony. A steady income made bribes and the selling of the sacrament less appealing, thought Langland and many others. Money has tempted many in the church to participate in shady deals at the cost of human suffering.[9]

7. The "one particular rule" difficulty could be extended to most of our temptations in general—the American Prohibition, for instance, turned out disastrous.

8. The collapse of the church is partially caused by the grasping greed of the friars in *Piers Plowman* C.XXII.

9. See Eugene McCarraher, *The Enchantments of Mammon: How Capitalism Became the Religion of Modernity* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 2019), for a devastating account of the church's complicity and convenient looking the other way with money during the rise of capitalism, especially regarding chattel slavery and prosperity gospel themes.

The way you get your money matters. The ends never justify the means, even if these means are legally and socially acceptable. Some avaricious ways of gaining money are obvious: theft, lying, fraud, and extortion. But there are also actions that, while legal, may not be right. Usury is the lending of money at very high rates, or any rates at all. Theoretically, medieval people believed Christians were not supposed to loan each other money with interest at all. Christians were supposed to loan freely and be ready to forgive those loans if the person couldn't pay them back in a reasonable way. Yet as it often happens with money, Christians found ways around these prohibitions that led to creatively awful results. The ruling Christian nobles who constantly needed to borrow money to fund wars and lavish lifestyles encouraged lending at interest from wealthy Jewish people. According to this system, the Jews could lend at interest because it wasn't Christian-to-Christian lending. Not only did this practice disregard the spirit of the warnings against usury by exploiting a loophole, it inflamed violent animosity and anti-Semitic stereotypes that still exist today.[10]

These rules feel strange to us today. Modern systems of credit cards, student loans, payday lending, and most mortgages would all have been considered sinful or at least questionable practices for early and medieval Christians to partake in as the person or institution loaning the money.[11] Today we live in a very

10. King Edward I even used usury as justification for expelling the Jews from England in 1290. See Julie Mell, "The Discourse of Usury and the Emergence of the Stereotype of the Jewish Usurer in Medieval France," in *The Myth of the Jewish Moneylender* (Palgrave MacMillan, 2018).

11. There is a robust, ancient Christian argument, rooted in the Hebrew Scriptures, for the forgiveness of long-term debt like student loans—fascinating given some of our current debates.

different economic society than feudalism, but remembering medieval people's moral qualms and missteps concerning lending at interest could lead us as Christians to fruitful questions about the central place of usury in our own economic systems—and perhaps reform.

Furthermore, the penitential manuals tell us, your career or craft matters. Formation does not happen in a vacuum. The things we do day-to-day lastingly shape us as we seek means to live. Medieval people held entertainment jobs like jugglers, public buffoons (I'm not exactly sure what that entails; perhaps some of our current American politicians apply), and heralds-at-arms (announcers for tournaments). They fell under a category one medieval book on penance calls "wicked crafts."[12] Prostitution and pimping were also included.

We might not categorize, say, sports announcers as "wicked" anymore. But I understand this as a challenge to us in postmodernity to attend to how our professions form our character. Some medieval penitential manuals posed questions based on the type of profession someone practiced, questions meant to help them recall and fully confess their sins.[13] The temptations of a pastor will differ from the temptations of a software engineer, which will also differ from the temptations of a caregiver of young children. How can we balance our glorification and pursuit of higher paid professions, like stockbrokers, professional athletes, tech folks, and so on, with the dearth of socially essential but undervalued

12. *The Book of Vices and Virtues: A Fourteenth Century English Translation of the Somme Le Roi of Lorens d'Orleans*, ed. W. Nelson Francis (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 41.

13. One example is the *Memoriale presbiterorum*, an instruction manual for priests that includes confession questions for specific social statuses and vocations (many thanks to Jessica Ward for the reminder).

positions like teachers, nurses, and garbage collectors? Because the ways we seek and earn money may shape us more than we realize, we are called to examine them. When profit becomes the bottom line, one can become especially prone to the habit of seeing dollar signs instead of people.

The School of Avarice

That our hearts stay with our treasure, whatever that is, reminds us that the deadliest aspect of avarice is its idolatry. *You cannot serve both God and money.* In disordered habits and desires toward money and possessions, on a practical level, we trust in the salvation of worldly goods and money to protect us from the vagaries of the universe. Avarice whispers that God's love is not superabundant but a limited resource that must always be buttressed by goods in case of a divine abandonment.

This behavior can occur quite subtly. The more I buy clothes or books, my two favorite expenditures, the more ideas I get for what else I want. I didn't know I wanted them until I saw them, but want them I do. (This burgeoning desire is, of course, aided and abetted by retailers and algorithm writers.) One could respond, "Grace, surely you aren't accumulating clothes or books with the idea of securing yourself against the abandonment of God." Certainly not on a conscious level. But am I buying them to feel better about myself or the world in a tactic I know will not work in the long run and distracts me from what is actually wrong? Sadly, yes. And so my petty idolatry gets me entangled in and feeds large-scale exploitative and ecological problems. Avarice's tentacles creep everywhere.

"But I'm not Jeff Bezos!" I may protest. Ultimately, avarice entails a habit of broken valuation influenced by but independent of actual possession. Humans always attempt to simplify avarice to something legible via dollar signs: *I couldn't be avaricious because I drive a dented Honda strewn with cracker crumbs, while she drives an immaculate Range Rover.* Yet the Desert Father Saint John Cassian grimly writes that "just as the words of the Gospel declare that even those who are not soiled in body have committed adultery in their heart, it is also possible for those who are not weighed down by money to be condemned along with the avaricious for their disposition and attitude. For it was the opportunity to possess that they lacked, not the desire."[14]

Ouch. This is why the Desert Mothers and Fathers, who did not own much of anything other than tattered robes, could still confess to avarice. However, it is simultaneously true that the more goods and money one possesses, the more opportunities one has to develop a habitual dependence on them that exceeds gratitude, fulfillment of basic need, and desire for good use.

A fourteenth-century monk, Michael of Northgate, translated one penitential text from the French that he called the *Ayenbite of Inwyt*, or the *Bite of Conscience*. In it, he describes avarice as a "greate scole" where all study and learn excessive desire, great and small, religious or not.[15] Since Brother Michael's time, Western Christians have unabashedly become doctoral candidates in consumerism. For most of us, myself included, it is avarice that instructs our habits

14. John Cassian, *The Institutes of the Cenobia and the Remedies for the Eight Principal Vices* 7.22, trans. Boniface Ramsey, OP, Ancient Christian Writers 58 (Newman, 2000). Initially found in Rebecca Konyndyk DeYoung *Glittering Vices: A New Look at the Seven Deadly Sins and Their Remedies*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2020), 119.

15. *Dan Michel's Ayenbite of Inwit*, ed. Richard Morris (N. Trübner for the Early English Text Society, 1866), 34.

of discerning what we need from what we want in terms of money and material possessions. How are we to leave this school behind?

Misericordia

Mercy. I breathe the word in and out in prayer; it animates my lungs in the liturgy. But I do not use it much outside the context of prayer. The Latin word for mercy is *misericordia*. Split this Latin word in two and you get the roots of our related modern word *misery* (*miseria*) and the Latin word for heart (*cor*). Mercy entails the gift of one's heart being pierced, materially moved, by the suffering of another. "Blessed are those whose heart is made miserable by another's want," as the *Summa virtutum* rephrases both Saint Bernard of Clairvaux and the beatitude itself (Matt. 5:7).[16] In acts of mercy, humans participate in the character of God's grace as they respond swiftly to the needs of others regardless of their merit or deeds. Mercy truly opposes avarice in every sense: Instead of participating in the dehumanization of others (and ultimately oneself) via the elevation of money and goods over people, mercy recollects personhood even in the most abject circumstances.

Mercy is "true profit," says *The Book of Vices and Virtues*, "a rich stone and precious that were good to all things."[17] Mercy practices proper reckoning, true valuing, good accounting in the economy of the kingdom of heaven, where all are made in Christ's image and all needy cries are worthy of attentive action. We live in a society that too often accords value to people via dollar signs,

16. *Summa virtutum*, 246.
17. *Book*, 195.

efficiency, productivity. But mercy exuberantly tramples over the usual divisions of prosperity and poverty, efficiency and inefficiency, skilled and unskilled. We all need that radical leveler, the mercy of God. God "is so *large* to us," joyfully muses the *Book*, and human mercy is our own outpour of this divine, capacious largesse.[18] In the midst of that joy of giving and receiving, mercy also entails sacrifice—the pain of witnessing, holding, and when possible, alleviating another's suffering. Mercy rejects the cultivated unseeing of avarice in favor of painful sight, of recognizing a fellow sufferer when one would really rather not. Highly inconvenient, always inefficient, sometimes excruciating.

Practicing mercy does not mean your heart is continually breaking in agony. Some folks are, indeed, given a particular gift of tears and lament.[19] But becoming a merciful person—a person who habitually practices mercy—does include cultivating a sensitivity and readiness to be broken. Often, this sensitivity and readiness is as simple as the acknowledgment that the one offering mercy is just as broken as the one receiving. Henri Nouwen, the beloved twentieth-century Catholic writer, urges us to recognize and "befriend" our individual brokenness and then place it under the blessing of God, "just as intimate a part of our being as our chosenness and our blessedness."[20] Recognition of the mutuality of our brokenness facilitates mercy. If we continually flee acknowledgment of our own brokenness, we will almost certainly flee the need

18. *Book*, 193.
19. We don't talk about this gift today as much, but in the Middle Ages, many people understood themselves as having the gift of tears for the world, like Margery Kempe or Saint Catherine of Siena. Perhaps this gift of the Holy Spirit is something worth pursuing and thinking about again.
20. Henri Nouwen, *Life of the Beloved: Spiritual Living in a Secular World* (New York: Crossroad, 1992), 75–76.

of others. The merciless do not recognize the unfillable depths of their own need; the merciful feel it with every bone and welcome it as kinship with one another in the far deeper mercy of God.

Illuminating, Cooking, Anointing

One of my favorite explanations of mercy comes from a popular sermon collection by the fifteenth-century cleric John Mirk.[21] Christ's body is like an olive tree, he says. Just as an olive tree yields olives and from them olive oil, Christ freely offers mercy, his flowing blood, from his wounded body. And like mercy, oil was used for many purposes. In the ancient and medieval world, oil fueled lamps that lit the dark premodern night. Though people do not often use oil for lamps anymore, mercy still resembles that flickering light. From relief workers risking their lives in natural disasters, to volunteers writing prisoners on death row, to blood donations pouring into hospitals after a mass shooting, mercy fuels a small flame's rebellion against the darkest moments of human violence or natural disaster. The defiant light of such mercy is what Fred Rogers famously directed us toward when he told frightened children (and adults) to "look for the helpers" in times of crisis.[22]

Oil is also used in cooking. I often cover the bottom of a hot pan with olive oil, pouring in mushrooms or vegetables or meat. The oil not only flavors the whole dish, every piece of it, but ensures things do not stick. In baking, oil binds ingredients together and provides moisture, but when lightly applied to the

21. John Mirk, *Mirk's Festial*, ed. Theodor Erbe (Early English Text Society, 1905), 152.

22. From a television interview, "Fred Rogers: Look for the Helpers," posted April 15, 2013, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-LGHtc_D328.

bottom of the pan, it also allows you to share without hacking it to pieces. Oil unites and divides with ease, covering and binding and paradoxically dividing, flavoring as it goes. As in oil, so in mercy. As it covers, mercy also divides, making it easy to share one's hard work in the pot, to give with joy. It can even flavor each action in dealing with someone difficult.

And lastly, oil was used in two highly sacred moments: to anoint monarchs at coronations and to bless the body as a soul left its earthly pilgrimage. We see the parallels between the oil of coronation and mercy in what the *Summa virtutum* calls the five species of mercy: to give, to lend, to pardon, to show compassion, and to correct the errors of others privately and kindly.[23] Mercy characterizes real leadership and authority as it gives and lends without taking advantage of the power afforded by money and distinction. Mercy gently corrects and pardons, as a merciful king does, saving his people from the full force of the awful consequences of their own decisions when he can. And at last, far from the glory of kingship, mercy is the only human thing left to us in our pain as we die. Nothing material can lastingly comfort the dying in the end; only human compassion can, in the bathing of a brow, in soft words, in keeping watch.

Ghostly and Bodily: The Seven Works of Mercy

The most popular, nearly universal way of conceptualizing mercy in the Middle Ages came in a list of deeds rather than an image or metaphor. For mercy, even more than other virtues, is an orientation of the heart that *flows into action*. A habit of mercy must

23. *Summa virtutum*, 260–2.

be cultivated. It will not develop automatically. To encourage this attitude and orientation toward mercy, medieval preachers and theologians taught a list of seven bodily (or corporeal) works of mercy, often accompanied by a list of seven spiritual ("ghostly") acts of mercy (bodily on top, spiritual on bottom):

1. To feed the poor.
2. To clothe the poor and the naked.
3. To lend to the needy and forgive their debts.
4. To visit and tend to the sick.
5. To welcome strangers and wanderers.
6. To visit and comfort prisoners.
7. To bury the dead.

1. To give good counsel.
2. To teach good to those you have authority over.
3. To chastise fools and wrongdoers.
4. To comfort the sick in heart and those in despair.
5. To forgive those who have trespassed against you.
6. To bear with sinners and the afflicted, for who is not a sinner?
7. To pray for all God's children.[24]

Material and spiritual care for other humans combats the affliction of avarice as each action bids one person to attend to another, one who could easily be ignored. These lists included no caveats about the worthiness or innocence of those in need. Visit

24. This list comes from *The Book of Vices and Virtues*, 204–209, and my word choice is a loose translation of the Middle English there. The list itself is nearly universal and ubiquitous.

the prisoners and aid them, regardless of what they've done. Feed and clothe those who need help, whether they are your own beloved children in your kitchen or strangers in the chains of drug addiction. Receiving strangers could include having a conversation with someone you are politically opposed to, talking to someone you don't know at church, or welcoming immigrants. These two sets of seven are remarkably flexible and at the heart of imitating Jesus.

The acts of mercy, also sometimes called acts of charity, do not only help others in need. They change us in our souls. Acting this way reorients us toward freedom and love and generosity itself. In the logic of habit, which slowly carves the heart like a river carving rock, each act of mercy forms our desire to truly see others beyond the life circumstances of pain and want in which they find themselves. The seven works of mercy do not make one the powerful patron we would all secretly like to be thought of as. Rather, they remind us that we are all needy and beloved embodied souls. Everyone appears on this list of those needing help. We were all once thirsty and naked babies, wailing at our mothers' breasts. I have been a stranger in a strange land before. You may remember a time you were a prisoner or lonely or ill. And every one of us will die. Our shared need of mercy places the truth of each life in clear brightness: *Everything we have is a gift.* The heart-knowledge of one's desperate need for mercy unlocks the sealed doors and covered windows of avarice.

Mercy and Justice Inextricable

This ancient list of bodily works of mercy originally stems from Matthew 25:31–46, in Christ's story of the sheep and the goats on

judgment day.[25] In a series of stories of what the kingdom of heaven is like, Christ begins his next story: "When the Son of Man comes in his glory . . ." As he sits on his throne over the world, he will divide the sheep and the goats. He explains that the sheep have fed him, clothed him, tended to him in his sickness and imprisonment. The goats did none of these things; they looked the other way. Both groups are shocked: *When did we ever do (or not do) those things for you?* And the Judge answers that when they did these things for anyone, they were caring for the Son of the Living God himself.

Justice has long been defined as the virtue that enables a person to render another person his due.[26] Justice asks, then acts on, what we owe to one another. We embodied, limited humans have long set justice and mercy at odds, as one being the virtue that punished and one being the virtue that omitted punishment.[27] But in Jesus Christ, these virtues are united, inextricable from one another. They are both virtues of judgment.

From the tail end of the Middle Ages, one stunning portrayal of the seven works of mercy illustrates the gospel words vividly. The anonymous "Master of Alkmaar" painted a series depicting each bodily work of mercy, which now dwells at the Rijksmuseum in Amsterdam.[28] The set of panels once hung in an almshouse, and then for another four centuries, a church, reminding worshipers of their call to practice mercy. Each panel portrays one of the seven acts. And in each panel, the painter has hidden in plain sight Christ himself.

25. Burying the dead is the only act that does not appear in Jesus's original words. It was added to the works of mercy later.

26. A paraphrase of Aquinas following Aristotle, *ST* II-II.58.1.r.

27. For more on this opposition and a general consideration of mercy and its tensions in historical Christian thought, see Alex Tuckness and John M. Parrish, *The Decline of Mercy in Public Life* (Cambridge, 2014), especially the introduction and ch. 3.

28. Master of Alkmaar, *The Seven Works of Mercy*, oil on wood, ca. 1504, Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam. See the detailed and helpful catalog entry on the artwork on the Rijksmuseum website, https://www.rijksmuseum.nl/en/collection/SK-A-2815/catalogue-entry, accessed March 29, 2024.

In the first three scenes (and the fifth), Jesus is one of the crowd of late medieval Dutch folk, distinguished only by his traditional long hair and beard. In the first panel, he looks straight out from the frame into the viewer's eyes. *Do you see me?* Jesus is thirsty in the crowd of unwashed, unimportant families. The pattern continues: Jesus is hungry. Jesus needs clothes. In the fourth panel, burying the dead, we get a cosmic glimpse of Matthew 25. Christ reigns above, showing his wounds in the traditional posture of medieval judgment day art.[29] But unlike traditional doomsday art, there are no graves opening up below, as the funeral goes on undisturbed. In the last two panels, the Master of Alkmaar shows us what else happens as we walk through the acts of mercy. Jesus is still in the frame, but in these last two scenes, he comforts prisoners. He tends to the sick. Viewers, called to mercy, can see *who* one becomes through the habit of acts of mercy.

We become Jesus as we learn to actively care for one another in our need. He, the man whose heart was literally pierced in the love and forgiveness of his enemies, is the embodiment of *misericordia*. But as the central panel reminds us, Christ is also enfleshed justice. As the only fair Judge of the hearts of humankind, he sees true value in full. Justice and mercy, not opposed but united in the only real Judge.

Mercy ends up not as excessive giving or generosity or pity or even simple compassion. *Mercy is the nearest human practice to*

29. Check out the Judge chapter from *Jesus Through Medieval Eyes* for more on this idea in medieval artwork of judgment day.

Master of Alkmaar, *The Seven Works of Mercy*, oil on wood, ca. 1504, Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam.

divine justice. Mercy is the closest equivalent to seeing how Jesus sees, to judging how Jesus judges, to loving how Jesus loves. It is rare for us to truly see what we owe to one another in our scattered blindness. But we can bear witness to our own mutual need and act on that in love. Mercy is the Christian's path into the perfect justice of God. With every act of mercy, my heart is pierced deeper and my eyes are opened wider to the presence of others—and the presence of Christ, in them, in me.

Practices and Prayer

> He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God? (Mic. 6:8 KJV)

Practices

- Reflect on these questions from two modern-day philosophers regarding your own use of money, and honestly share with a trusted friend, family member, or spouse:
  - *From Fr. Andrew Pinsent: Is your orientation toward money governed by human relationship?*[30]
  - *From Rebecca Konyndyk DeYoung: "If I keep handling possessions like this for the next ten or twenty years, what sort of character will I develop and what kind of person will I become?"*[31]

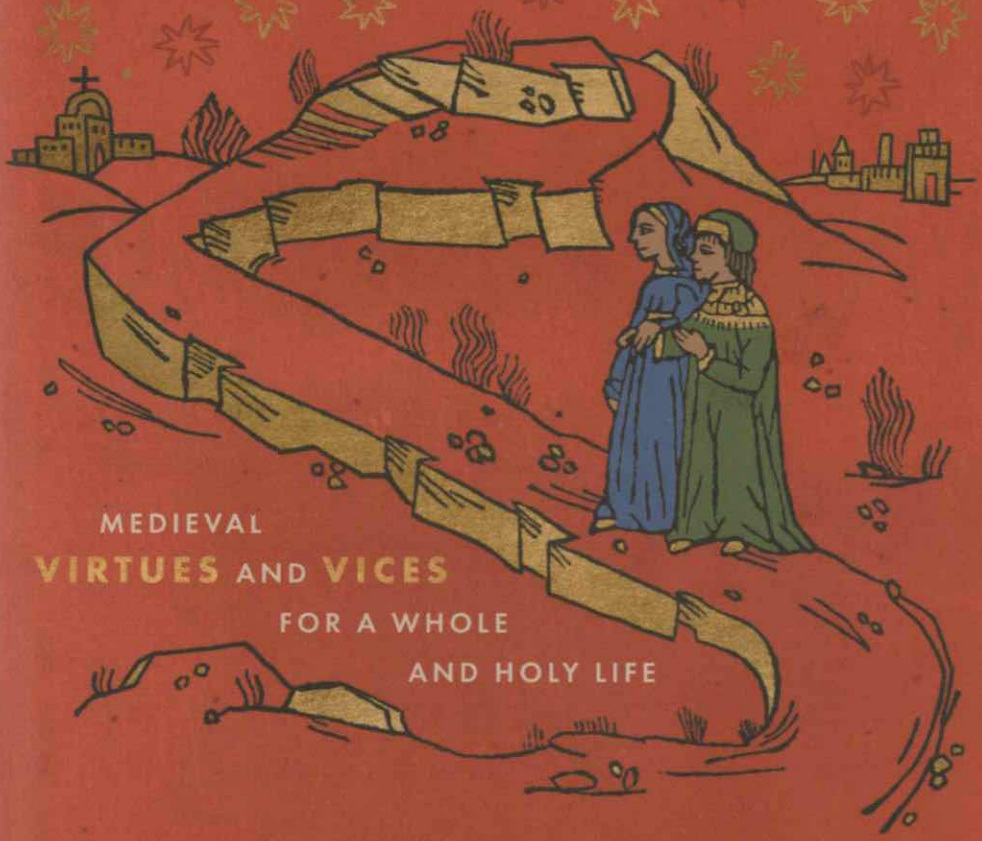
30. Pinsent, "Mercy and Avarice," *Virtues*, 172–4.
31. DeYoung, *Glittering Vices*, 114.

- Go out of your way to practice each of the seven bodily acts of mercy and the seven spiritual acts of mercy during a specific time period (the next month, Lent or Advent, over the next year). Some you might already do every day (caregivers to family members, I see you!), and some will be more elusive.
- Read further on mercy: *Just Mercy* by Bryan Stevenson, *Silas Marner* by George Eliot, *Piers Plowman* by William Langland (I recommend the translation by George Economou).

Prayer

Lord Jesus, make me merciful in body and soul. Have mercy on me, for I have ignored and hurt others by my acquisitive consumption. Detach my heart from the iron grip that my possessions have on me. Help me to use my money and material possessions wisely and well. Teach me how to spend, save, and give freely, guided by my relationships with my neighbor and creation. Give me your eyes, true vision, to see the image of God in every person I meet. Pierce my heart when I see need, and move me to act on that piercing so that I may follow you into true justice and mercy. Amen.

ASK *of* OLD PATHS



MEDIEVAL **VIRTUES** AND **VICES** FOR A WHOLE AND HOLY LIFE

GRACE HAMMAN

Foreword by JESSICA HOOTEN WILSON